

Birds in Danger

ALL OVER THE WORLD, bird species are in danger of going extinct. When this happens, every member of a kind of bird dies and the species is lost forever. About 13 percent of birds are threatened with extinction. Over millions of years, bird species die out naturally and new ones evolve to take their place. But within

the last few centuries, humans have sped up the extinction process. They increase threats to bird survival by destroying habitats, causing pollution, hunting birds, and trapping them to keep in cages. Many kinds of birds urgently need our help. Fortunately, there are people out there working to conserve birds.

Threatened birds

These are some bird species that have been endangered with extinction. Some, such as the ivory-billed woodpecker, are now probably extinct. But others, such as the St. Vincent parrot, have been saved by protection of their habitat or through captive breeding.



Eskimo curlew
(*Numenius borealis*)
Americas



Ivory-billed woodpecker
(*Campephilus principalis*)
Americas



Chatham Island black robin
(*Petroica traversi*)
New Zealand



Noisy scrubbird
(*Atrichornis clamosus*)
Australia



Gurney's pitta
(*Pitta gurneyi*)
Thailand



St. Vincent parrot
(*Amazona guildingii*)
Americas



Greater Philippine eagle
(*Pithecophaga jefferyi*)

Habitat destruction

This is the most serious threat to bird life today. Bird species are adapted to live in particular habitats, and when these habitats are destroyed, the birds that rely on them may disappear. Humans have changed bird habitats because of the ways we use the land. Forests are cleared for timber and farming, grasslands

are changed into crops, wetlands are drained, and shorelines have been used for building. Some of these habitats are home to such a rich variety of species that, when they are destroyed, hundreds of bird species become threatened with extinction. Twenty percent of the Amazon rainforest is already gone. Deforestation in the Philippines has driven the Philippine eagle to the edge of extinction. In order to help protect bird species, countries around the world set aside areas of habitat that are preserved. These reserves aim to keep birds and other wildlife safe.



The Asian crested ibis was nearly lost to extinction because its wetland habitats—such as rice paddies—were converted to dry wheat crops, and its nesting trees were felled.



Asian crested ibis
(*Nipponia nippon*)



Hunting

Some species of birds are deliberately targeted by human hunters. In the 1880s, many birds, such as egrets, were killed for their showy feathers, which ended up in women's hats. Concern over species decline led to two new important bird conservation organizations: the National

Audubon Society in the US and the RSPB (Royal Society for the Protection of Birds) in the UK. They helped set up new laws to protect birds, but this came too late for some. The dodo and the passenger pigeon were both ruthlessly hunted to extinction. When so many adult birds are killed in such a short space of time that they cannot breed quickly enough, the species becomes extinct. Hunting birds for food is not so common today, but many species are still killed for sport, and birds that follow the same migration routes each year are easy targets.



People collect thousands of common murre eggs from breeding colonies off the coasts of the Faroe Islands.



Great Indian bustard
(*Ardeotis nigriceps*)

Widespread hunting for food and sport has left the great Indian bustard critically endangered.